

Flipping strongholds

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Introduction

Strongholds are centers of thought and belief that shape our reality and impact our day-to-day speech and actions. When our strongholds are assembled together, they make up our worldview, or our mindset to think about the world and our experiences in it, having effect on all of the decisions we make.

The ideas we regularly think about and believe have consequences. They have consequences in the way we live our lives and how that affects those in our sphere of influence. Ideas more broadly adopted affect groups, institutions, whole societies, nations and the world.

One significant example is the ideas of communism that began with Karl Marx, which went on to affect other individuals, then groups, institutions, whole societies and nations. The ideas of Marx have impacted the world. We see the effects of those impacts in nations including China, North Korea, Vietnam and Cuba, and also in places where communism formerly took hold: Russia, Iran, Somalia, and Afghanistan.

The concept is not limited to such examples though. We all have strongholds of thought and belief. Put together, they affect the values of the groups, institutions and societies we comprise. These strongholds are also the primary target for influence by the unseen, yet very real, spiritual world that surrounds us: "For though we walk in the flesh, we are not waging war according to the flesh. For the weapons of our warfare are not of the flesh but have divine power to destroy strongholds. We destroy arguments and every lofty opinion raised against the knowledge of God, and take every thought captive to obey Christ,
2 Corinthians 10:3-5 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/2co.10.3-5.ESV>

Our thinking is influenced by so many factors. Interest. Desire. Family. Education. Media. Our senses. Experiences. Tradition. (See my book [Reality](#) for more on this.)

What we continue to think on creates thought patterns, then strongholds. These strongholds are the high places in our thought life that intersect and form our belief system. These strongholds and core beliefs underpin who we are and what we are about. As such, they affect what we choose to say and do.

As creatures of free will, we are capable of change, for better or worse, as long as we live and breathe. When it comes to new formation or to reformation, what we continue to say and do affects our practices, our habits, and, ultimately, our character. From this comes our "fruit," whether good or bad. The visible fruit is the tip of the iceberg, so to speak.

Our fruit is what goes on display from our nature and character. As our Master taught, "So, every healthy tree bears good fruit, but the diseased tree bears bad fruit. A healthy tree cannot bear bad fruit, nor can a diseased tree bear good fruit."

Matthew 7:17-18 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/mat.7.17-18.ESV>

All bad trees are of Satan (John 8:34-44, Ephesians 2:1-3). All good trees are of Christ, for only God is good (Mark 10:18). Christ has a mind and thoughts: the mind and the thoughts of the Spirit of God. If we are in Christ, we have been given that mind (1 Corinthians 2:16).

Yet, there is a battle over our minds, even among those who have chosen to follow Jesus Christ. New Christians are double-minded (James 1:8, 4:8), and it is our work to cooperate with the Spirit of God we've been given to renew our minds (Romans 12:2, Ephesians 4:23-24, Colossians 3:10) to think correctly, according to the word of God.

Without doing this, we cannot live right and we cannot please God:

"For those who live according to the flesh set their minds on the things of the flesh, but those who live according to the Spirit set their minds on the things of the Spirit. For to set the mind on the flesh is death, but to set the mind on the Spirit is life and peace. For the mind that is set on the flesh is hostile to God, for it does not submit to God's law; indeed, it cannot. Those who are in the flesh cannot please God."

Romans 8:5-8 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/rom.8.5-8.ESV>

In discipleship, we choose to cooperate with the Spirit's work in us. The Spirit of God works to flip the strongholds in our mind. God wants to hold those high places in us. God seeks to cause us to think and believe differently, according to the mind of Christ, acting on that belief as if it were reality. That is repentance. It yields change in our nature and character, in speech and deed, yielding good fruit that glorifies God. If we choose to daily course-correct to think and to walk as Christ thought and walked, we will reflect God's glory and goodness and love, according to His intent in His perfect blueprint of His word.

Separating ourselves unto God, as Christ did, requires having an accurate understanding of what we separate ourselves from: the devil and his devices. His devices are to cause doubt, to deceive, to discredit, to denounce, to distract, to disorient, to divide, to dispossess, to distress, to destroy.

As we consider the devices whereby the enemy seeks to gain strongholds in us, we move next to think about how that stronghold may be flipped so that God will hold the high places instead.

Devil

The devil, or Satan, is an angel who tried to exalt himself above God, and was cast out of heaven to earth along with the angels (demons) in league with him (Isaiah 14:12-17, Revelation 12:7-12). Jesus called him a thief who “comes only to steal and kill and destroy” (John 10:10).

The Bible teaches that unbelievers are in subjection to Satan’s authority (Acts 26:18, 1 John 5:19). He subjected mankind to the law of sin and death by convincing them to disobey God, doing as he pleased. This forfeited the right of mankind to be royal sons and daughters of God, under God’s rule and government and blessing unto eternal inheritance. Mankind was in all ways disconnected from their good Father, who was legally replaced by the devil of disobedience and death himself. Although made in God’s nature and likeness, mankind would naturally take after the devil as father rather than God as Father (John 8:31-44), doing what pleased them (Ephesians 2:1-3).

In the life of a Christ follower, the devil has no authority (Matthew 28:18, Philippians 2:9-11). Yet, the devil still has ability. The Bible teaches that the devil and his demons have the ability to affect human ideas, thinking, temptation, desires, emotions, will, health, institutions, governments, social structures, and society at large. Jesus suggested that his influence would be dominant when he taught that “the gate is wide and the way is easy that leads to destruction, and those who enter by it are many” (Matthew 7:13).

The devil is real and has real influence in this world. We wrestle here not against flesh and blood but against the rule and government of Satan and demons and their evil purposes on earth (Ephesians 6:12). They rule and govern by ability and influence, especially through their children of disobedience (Ephesians 2:1-3). Christ followers must be aware of “the schemes of the devil” (Ephesians 6:11) so they may together oppose them in Christ.

The devil is death and everything associated with it. Clearly, the flip of this is life. God is life. By His spoken, creative word, God originally gave life to mankind as He intended, and Christ, the word of God made flesh, came to restore it to us. Jesus testified that He “came that [we] may have life and have it abundantly” (John 10:10). In Christ, we have been directly connected to God, who is life. Jesus also testified, “For the gate is narrow and the way is hard that leads to life, and those who find it are few.” (Matthew 7:14)

Doubt

Satan was able to disown God's kingdom children by causing them to doubt the goodness of God, making them think He was holding back good from them. Satan introduced doubt in a question, "Did God actually say?" (Genesis 3:1)

Have you doubted God's goodness? Have you believed He was withholding good from you? Satan still causes us to doubt God and His goodness. He causes us to doubt God's word as truth. He causes us to doubt God's provision. He causes us to doubt our salvation and all that comes with it. As those who have been saved, he causes us to doubt our identity in Christ. He causes us to doubt Christ's sufficiency to give us victory over our sin. He causes us to doubt God's willingness to answer our prayers. He causes us to doubt all reality apart from what's seen and experienced through our five senses.

Have you doubted God in these ways? How have you seen that doubt manifest itself in others?

The flip of doubt is belief. It's trust. It leads to faith.

It's belief in the Bible as God's word to you. It's belief in the way it communicates God's good character and nature. It's belief in Jesus Christ as the way, the truth and the life for you and everyone.

It's trusting in God's provision for you as promised in God's word. It's trusting in the fullness of salvation as communicated in God's word. It's trusting that you are who God says you are in Jesus Christ.

It's faith that Christ's sacrifice is enough for you to defeat whatever besetting sin has been holding you back (1 John 5:4-5). It's faith that Jesus Christ will answer the prayers you pray for God's glory (Mark 9:23, John 14:13). It's faith in all of the unseen realities of God's kingdom described in the truth of God's word.

Faith is an action based on trust in God. Faith steps out. Faith speaks.

To what extent has trust in God become a stronghold in your thinking? How much does it translate to what you speak? How much does it translate to what you do every day?

Deceive

Jesus testified that the devil “does not stand in the truth, because there is no truth in him. When he lies, he speaks out of his own character, for he is a liar and the father of lies” (John 8:44). In Revelation, he is described as “the deceiver of the whole world” (Revelation 12:9). Paul testified that “Satan disguises himself as an angel of light” (2 Corinthians 11:14).

The devil’s strategy is to sow and to nurture deceitful ideas such that truth is concealed or misrepresented to the end that we will not believe the truth and act on it. He deceives many to make them think he isn’t real. As such, he deceives many to make them think evil is not real. He deceives many to make them think he doesn’t affect their thoughts. He deceives many to make them think that when they hear the voice of a devil, they are hearing their own voice. He deceives many to make them think that God and the spiritual world are a myth created by man. He deceives many to make them think that hell is a myth. For people who believe in God and heaven, he deceives many to make them think they have met God’s criteria to go to heaven. He deceives many who lead organizations, institutions and governments to think that their values and ways are right and virtuous. He deceives many to make them think they cannot understand truth apart from reason and observation. He deceives many to make them think they should live for today. He deceives many to think that the desires of the flesh and mind are natural and, therefore, harmless. He deceives many to make them think sickness and pain are purely physical problems rather than things tied to the law of sin and death he introduced into God’s creation. He deceives many to make them think there’s no spiritual component to mental health. He introduces deceitful ideas and traditions of men into the doctrines of churches. He deceives many to make them think there is advantage to lying and hypocrisy. All such schemes of deceit, as well as the strongholds they have created within people, groups, institutions, and governments, are associated with Satan’s domain of darkness.

Jesus’ teaching was clear that those who belong to Satan follow after his deceitful ways (John 8:38-44). Paul testified that they are even disguised as apostles, workmen, and servants in God’s church (2 Corinthians 11:13-14).

The flip of deceit is the truth. It is light. It’s the truth revealed in the word of God, and especially by Jesus Christ, the word of God made flesh. We are to know the truth, live the truth, and openly speak the truth. As disciples of Christ, the word of God is to dwell richly in us (Colossians 3:16). We are to walk as Jesus walked (1 John 2:6) and do what Jesus did, Christ in us. We are commanded to proclaim the gospel (Matthew 24:14, Mark 16:15) and give testimony (Luke 21:13-15, Acts 1:8). Jesus was the light of the world while He was here, and now His disciples are the light of the world (Mark 5:16).

To what extent has the truth of the word of God shaped your reality? Do you recognize deceit in all of its forms? Are you living as light to the world around you?

Discredit

Another scheme of Satan is to cause harm to the reputation of God and His children. This was especially visible in the ministry of Jesus Christ, who “God anointed with the Holy Spirit and with power. He went about doing good and healing all who were oppressed by the devil, for God was with him” (Acts 10:38). Yet, the Pharisees called this work of the Spirit the work of Satan (Beelzebub) instead (Matthew 12:22-32). They caused people to say about Jesus, “he is out of his mind” (Mark 3:20). Jesus called this defamation blasphemy against the Holy Spirit. Similarly, the Jewish leaders sought to discredit the apostles, including Paul. They called him “a plague, one who stirs up riots among all the Jews throughout the world and is a ringleader of the sect of the Nazarenes. He even tried to profane the temple...” (Acts 24:5-6). Satan’s tactic is to influence those who have influence in order to attempt to stop the influence of God in the world.

The devil still seeks ways to discredit the ministry of Christ and Christ followers, thereby causing defamation to God. Today, the healing evangelism that Christ and the apostles practiced has been almost completely discredited, even among most churches. It’s been associated with televangelism, which has also largely been discredited due to abuses. The devil also seeks ways to discredit the Bible as God’s word. Further, he has used influence to discredit God’s word as law, taking the Ten Commandments out of the courthouses it used to be in. He has used influence to discredit God’s word as a tool to teach values, as history, and as literature, taking the Bible out of public schools. Further, he looks to discredit any religious basis for morality, making people think they can be good apart from the existence of God and His law. For those who believe in God, he seeks to discredit God’s good character, making it seem like a good God wouldn’t send people to hell. He seeks to discredit the love of God, making it seem unloving to believe that Jesus is the only way to salvation, especially in a society now so aware of the rest of the world. He seeks to discredit the supernatural in general, relegating it to a thing of entertainment and myth. He seeks to discredit belief in the unseen, elevating reason instead. He seeks to discredit church leaders by causing them to stray into sexual sin. He seeks to defame God’s church in general.

The flip of discredit and defamation is fame and good reputation. It’s the glory of God and His workmanship. As children of God, it is our job to make God famous. It’s our charge to exalt Jesus Christ and the fullness of the salvation that He provided. Our work is to cooperate with God’s indwelling Spirit to continue the ministry of Jesus Christ, forcefully advancing the kingdom of God in this world (Matthew 11:12), thereby discrediting, defaming, and defeating Satan and his inferior ability. The kingdom of God is His government and His rule. It’s anywhere His will is done. Our charge is to cooperate with God to cause things on earth to be as they are in heaven (Matthew 6:10). This obedience brings glory and thanksgiving to God. He alone is worthy.

Has some of the supernatural work accomplished by the Holy Spirit in this world been discredited in your eyes? If so, how can you better honor the Spirit? Further, how can you use the influence and ability God has given you to make Him famous?

Denounce

The devil is described as “the accuser of our brothers (or brothers and sisters)... who accuses them day and night before our God” (Revelation 12:10). Paul’s letter to the Colossians reveals that the devil’s “rulers and authorities” look to use against us the record of debt from our sins along with their legal demands (Colossians 2:14). This describes God’s spiritual law that came into effect because of disobedience, also called the “law of sin and death” (Romans 8:2). God’s law includes blessings for obedience and curses unto destruction for disobedience (Deuteronomy 28:15-68), and Satan’s realm looks to take advantage of the latter. Satan looks to use his ability to express his “great wrath” (Revelation 12:12) against God’s image bearers (human beings, Genesis 1:26-27) until the time he is judged (Revelation 20:10). Jesus gave some insight into the way Satan looks to use God’s legal system when he said to Simon Peter, “Simon, Simon, behold, Satan demanded to have you, that he might sift you like wheat, but I have prayed for you that your faith may not fail” (Luke 22:31). In sifting, wheat is spread onto a floor made of stone, concrete or tamped earth, and it is beaten with a flail, ground up and pulverized.

In order to put us into legal debt that he can exploit, the devil has the ability to interact with our sinful nature to tempt us to sin (1 Chronicles 21:1, John 13:2, Acts 5:3, 2 Corinthians 11:3, Ephesians 4:26-27, James 1:14). Sin is simply the choice that goes against the choice that comes from faith in God and His word (Romans 14:23). His method is to gain in us any toehold, then work to turn it into a foothold, and, eventually, a stronghold. By way of gaining a stronger place in our thought life, the devil is also the one to cause us to feel prolonged guilt, shame and condemnation for any past offense. He seeks to put us in any kind of bondage that is possible.

In addition to his attempts to throw anything in God’s legal system against image bearers, the devil is also prone to slander. In fact that’s the meaning of the word devil (diabolos in Greek). He is the false accuser, which links back to his fundamental nature of deception. He seeks to convince us we are *not enough*, even with Christ. He seeks out ways to denounce God, denounce Christians, and denounce the Christian church and its work in the world.

The flip of accusation is forgiveness. It’s in God’s merciful nature to set the repentant free from their offenses against him. He also commands us to forgive freely, right away, and as many times as any situation would require (Matthew 18:21-22; Luke 6:36-37; Ephesians 4:26,31-22). Jesus came to fulfill the desire of the Spirit of God to set captives free (Isaiah 61:1, Luke 4:18-19), and we are to continue this ministry.

To repent means to change your mind. It’s to set a new course that thinks differently, speaks differently, acts differently, according to the mind and purpose and the ways of Jesus Christ.

Are you living a life of repentance? If so, the record of debt against you has been canceled by the finished work of Jesus Christ (Colossians 2:13-15). Satan’s realm is completely disarmed, having no authority with respect to you. If you have been struggling against a particular sin, know that Christ living in you is more than enough to give you victory over it. Walk away now.

We have become the righteousness of God (2 Corinthians 5:21), and righteousness always has victory (1 Corinthians 15:57; 2 Corinthians 2:14; 1 John 4:4, 5:4).

Is there anything you are holding against a brother or sister? Set them free today so Satan has nothing in you (Ephesians 4:27), not even a toehold. Live as one who has been set free.

Are you actively participating in God's ministry of reconciliation (2 Corinthians 5:17-20)? We have been made co-workers together with God (Mark 16:20, 1 Corinthians 3:9, 2 Corinthians 5:20, 2 Corinthians 6:1), in Christ's place, to see other people free and to connect them to the free flow of the goodness of God. The immeasurable riches of God's grace and kindness (Ephesians 2:7) are for them too. Allow God to channel His life through you (John 7:38-39).

Distract

Jesus spoke to those things that would distract us from the repentant life of following Him as Lord, the narrow path of salvation. He addressed distraction by riches in the parable of the rich fool who tore down His barns to build larger ones (Luke 12:13-21) and His call to the rich young man to give away everything he had to follow Him (Matthew 19:16-24). He addressed distraction by other relationships, especially with the opposite sex, both in His teaching on sexual temptation in the Sermon on the Mount (Matthew 5:27-30) and in His call to forsake spouse and family to be His disciple (Luke 9:59-62; 14:25-33). He addressed reputation as a distraction, most often making a negative example of the hypocritical Pharisees, who enjoyed their high position in Jewish society (Matthew 6:1-8, 16-18). In the parable of the sower, he called these distractions “the cares of the world and the deceitfulness of riches and the desires for other things” (Mark 4:19).

The distraction of the busy world we live in is a construct of the devil, playing to our disordered desires. He seeks to waste our time, attention, and energy as much as possible, even on relatively good things. He causes us to primarily seek our own comfort, entertainment, and pleasure. He causes us to focus on positioning ourselves to build our careers and our retirements. He causes us to think we are the ones responsible to bring good things to ourselves and our families. This, in turn, causes anxiety. Further, he causes us to seek out relationships and experiences that bring us satisfaction. He causes us to build our own kingdoms, seeking our own glory and our own legacy. He makes some people prosperous and comfortable so they think earth is their home. He distracts others with adversity, temptation, and monotony in the long middle stage of life, causing their desire for good to wane. He makes us so busy focusing on ourselves and our own stories that we do not take the necessary time to focus on God and His ideas, plans, priorities, goals, objectives, agenda, dreams, desires, will, and story. The devil’s device is to introduce any and all distractions that would cause us to veer from walking after Christ on His own path. If hell has a characteristic, it is that of distraction.

The flip of distraction is focus. It is the focus on our direct connection to God in Christ (1 Corinthians 6:17). It is the focus in regular, consistent prayer to align and partner with Him in His ideas, plans, priorities, goals, objectives, agenda, dreams, desires, will, and story. It is the single-minded focus that results from consistently cooperating with the indwelling Spirit of God to think His thoughts and to step out in faith to obey His words. This is how we come to walk as Jesus walked.

What has your attention?

What has been distracting you?

What will you do about it? Will you do what’s necessary to flip that stronghold?

Disorient

The strongholds that the devil's realm have secured within humans over the ages have served to build the present world system that is upside down from the ways of God's kingdom, as described more from all of the relevant scripture references in my book [The Gospel of the Kingdom](#). In particular, the gospel of Matthew details Jesus' teachings on His kingdom, where those who are first in this world become last and the last become first. The distortions introduced by God's adversaries to the sinful society we live in are meant to disorient and confuse even God's faithful, especially those newly born. Those who do not follow Christ are described in scripture as outright blind (2 Corinthians 4:4).

In this world, pursuit of knowledge apart from God is exalted. In this world, the devil creates fake news and disinformation to confuse what is true. He confuses the purpose of any holidays that have Christian significance. The good that Christians have done in history has been obscured in order to paint God and His church either as a nuisance or an enemy that halts the forward progress of society. He causes many to think that society continues to improve over time, so that any changes brought about by the masses are beneficial. The values of the world are contrary to those of God's, yet cloaked to appear as good. Through his world system, the devil makes many think that lust is love. Meanwhile, speaking about your Christian beliefs may be considered as hate speech, public preaching is offensive, and door-to-door evangelism is extreme. He causes you to think that you are the center of the world. In fact, it's all about you and your story. He seeks to make you think that your will and desires for your life are God's will and desires for your life, and God works for you to make it come to pass. He causes you to think that you, or possibly you and your family, are better than other people, or at least that you should functionally live as though you are. He causes you to think your nation is better than other nations. He causes many to think that refugees are lesser human beings who do not deserve the same treatment they do. He causes many to think that the homeless are lesser human beings who deserve the conditions they live in. He causes many to think that wealth and resources are zero sum games, so they should look out for themselves. He causes us to think that physicians and hospitals are our only trustworthy option for healing. He confuses many as to whom they should look to as Christ's church in the world.

The flip is to reorient in order to see rightly so that we may continue to walk in the one right direction: the direction Christ walked. Reorienting is only possible through the obedient faith in Jesus Christ that allows us to change our thinking, which is repentance. We must daily reorient ourselves to the truth of the word of God, the blueprint of what is right. His word rightly shows who you are, who God is, what you should value, and what your responsibility is while you are in this world that is not your home. Our responsibilities are no different than those of the obedient disciples that followed Jesus Christ in the scriptures.

How has this world disoriented you? How will you flip any stronghold of disorientation?

Divide

Jesus taught that “if a house is divided against itself, that house will not be able to stand” (Mark 3:25). He referred to the way Satan would not act contrary to his own interests by casting demons out of people, healing every disease and affliction (Matthew 10:1), as Jesus and His apostles had been doing, proclaiming that the kingdom of heaven is at hand (Mark 3:14-15, Matthew 10:7). Division causes any house or kingdom to weaken. In fact, the major objective of Christ’s ministry is to put Satan and everything associated with him under foot (Luke 10:17-18, Acts 10:38, 1 Corinthians 15:24-25, 1 John 3:8).

The Apostle Paul’s first letter to the Corinthian church addressed division within it. They were divided based on who had discipled them (1 Corinthians 1:10-13, 3:3-4). They were starting lawsuits against each other (1 Corinthians 6:1-8). They were unable to share food and communion with each other (1 Corinthians 11:18-22). They were unable to function as a body because of selfishness and immaturity (1 Corinthians 12:14-25).

The devil’s scheme is to divide God’s image bearers in every conceivable way. The devil causes division in marriages. He causes division in families. His realm is dividing God-created gender into as many fractions (currently over 100 by one report) as can be conceived, with one of them, a “two spirit,” that is particularly revealing of the true situation. He causes division in friendships. He causes division in workplaces. He spurs you on to react emotionally in situations, then to hold onto that emotion, letting it fester. He causes division and disinterest among neighbors. He causes division within countries. He gives us reasons to dislike refugees and aliens. He causes divisions among countries. He causes division in the actual body of Christ. He also causes division “in the traditions of men” (Mark 7:7-8) associated with all of the 45,000+ Christian denominations in the world. In turn, this causes people to divide themselves from those perceived to be in His church. Yet, scripture warns that this is “no wonder, for even Satan disguises himself as an angel of light. So it is no surprise if his servants, also, disguise themselves as servants of righteousness” (2 Corinthians 11:15).

The flip of a divide is to unite. The Spirit of God loves the unity of His faith-filled children (John 17:21-23). This unity stirs up the Spirit (Mark 16:20, Acts 4:23-34). The way to unity among believers is for each one to seek to be “of the same mind, having the same love, being in full accord” (Philippians 2:2). It is to bear “with one another in love, eager to maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace,” recognizing “There is one body and one Spirit” (Ephesians 4:4). Since we each have our own mind, the way to unity is through renewing our minds (Romans 12:2, Ephesians 4:22-24) to “put on” the mind of Christ (1 Corinthians 2:16) that was made ours in our new birth. This mind to be *put on* as clothing in cooperation with the Spirit of God that abides in us. We clothe ourselves by putting God’s word into practice, because our mind is only renewed to the words of God to the extent that we put each word into practice. In the same way, we are to “put on love, which binds everything together in perfect harmony” (Colossians 3:14). Our good works make bonds of love, which are the ligaments, tendons, and fascia that hold us together, e.g., connecting bone to bone and other muscles, thereby allowing proper function.

God is calling His church to unity. For more on this, see www.teams.church.

Dispossess

Jesus taught that if we will seek it, it is our Father's good pleasure to give us the kingdom (Luke 12:32). Our inheritance in His kingdom has already begun for Christ followers in that God has "raised us up with him and seated us with him in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus, so that in the coming ages he might show the immeasurable riches of his grace in kindness toward us in Christ Jesus" (Ephesians 2:6-7). God has made us joint heirs with Jesus Christ (Romans 8:17); identified fully with Him, we have what He has. The down payment (or earnest, in the KJV) of this inheritance for disciples of Christ is the Holy Spirit that Jesus promised to us (John 14:15-23, Ephesians 1:13-14), who lives in us now, the same Spirit that raised Jesus Christ from the dead (Romans 8:11). The Spirit is our gift from God now, and, believing, we have now what the Spirit has, God's own character and nature included (1 Corinthians 2:16, Ephesians 1:3, 2 Peter 1:3-4). Further, when we seek His kingdom (Matthew 6:33) and have faith that He supplies our every need, He also does that as well (Phillipians 4:19).

Our heavenly Father had originally created us as His children with such a rich inheritance, although God's legal system allowed for the possibility of sin to dispossess us. Exploiting that, the devil took our glorious inheritance and God's human family, created in His image, away at the same time. By leading humanity into sin, the devil inherited the world and its kingdoms, first given to the dominion of mankind, and became father to every nonbeliever (Genesis 1:26-30, Matthew 4:8-9, John 8:44, Ephesians 2:3). As believers, the devil still leads us into sin to dispossess us, for we cannot definitely possess His abiding Spirit when we choose to live in disobedience (Acts 5:32, 1 Thessalonians 5:19). Without welcoming God's Spirit to live and reign in us, we do not have the rest of His inheritance either. And so we are dispossessed of the riches that come from full identification with Jesus Christ: freedom, life, victory, and the fruits of the Spirit. Rejecting His gift, we leave ourselves open to the devil's robbery. As a thief, the devil has the ability to take despite having no authority to do so.

The flip of taking is giving. God is a benevolent, generous giver. He created us to have open hands to give, just as Christ gave everything unto His very life. To become generous like He is, we need to definitely possess His abiding Spirit, who alone can create that nature in us. This means surrendering all to his lordship, every room of our lives. (See my book [Rooms](#).) For us to become like Christ, giving like God's character and nature gives, is to reflect His own majesty and glory. It's to return ourselves to God's glorious possession. This brings Him glory. He is worthy of it.

What do you not yet possess that God's word says is yours now in Christ?

My book [Identity in Christ: Characteristics of Christ in you](#) addresses what God's word says is yours. The greatest thing we can possess is God Himself. Jesus went to heaven in order that the very treasury of the heart of the Eternal God might be unlocked for your benefit.

Distress

Scripture says that when the devil was defeated and thrown down from heaven, he came down in great wrath because he knew his time was short (Revelation 12:7-12). We live during this short time and in the place of his domain. Since the devil has no ability to fight God directly, he causes distress to His treasured possession (1 Peter 2:9): we who are made in His image (Genesis 1:26-27), just a little lower than Himself (Psalm 8:3-6).

The devil inflicts every kind of distress. We are able to explain and begin to address these things with science and medicine, and yet there are spiritual parallels to every physical distress, no different than during the ministry of Jesus Christ. The very real spiritual world is here and now in our midst; it's in a dimension beyond the measurement of our five senses and any instrument of man's making. It is the devil who causes extreme anxiety in this world. The manifestation of his devices are the source of upset and sorrow. He is the source of pain; it would not exist without him. He is the reason for every affliction and torment. The manifestation of his devices cause all suffering and misery. The longer we observe and hear about the distresses in this world, the more we are instructed in the fear that motivates much of what we do.

None of this is from God. It isn't God's will to use these things; that isn't His design, but rather a byproduct of having given freedom to His creation to choose. He is the God of freedom – not bondage, and not distress.

The flip of distress is peace (shâlôm). It means completeness, safety, soundness in body, welfare, health, prosperity, tranquility, contentment, and friendship. It is the characteristic of heaven.

To His disciples, Christ says "I have said these things to you, that in me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world" (John 16:33). Peace comes to those obedient disciples who definitely possess His own Spirit (Romans 14:17) and take on His own mind (1 Corinthians 2:16, Colossians 3:9-15). In every trial, we must choose faith in the thing that follows from our belief in God's goodness and His word, if we are to grow in the maturity that will bring us God's peace and love. As we grow in His own character of love, it casts out fear from us (1 John 4:18). We instead become compelled to act by God's own tender love. This is Jesus' heart: He is moved by compassion (Matthew 9:35-36). Jesus' genuine love sees evil and its effects, abhors them, and acts to overcome evil with good (Romans 12:9,21). God's love is not a feeling. God's love doesn't sit on its hands. Our Lord Jesus Christ is the same now (Hebrews 13:8), and He *lives in us* (Colossians 1:27).

Christ lives through *you*.

Destroy

Jesus taught that the devil was a murderer from the beginning (John 8:44) who only comes to kill and destroy (John 10:10). Peter cautioned the church to be watchful because our “adversary the devil prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour” (1 Peter 5:8).

The devil is responsible for the persecution and murder of God’s prophets, including Jesus and all of his apostles in the scriptures, except John, according to tradition. In great wrath because his time is short (Revelation 12:7-12), he seeks to destroy: all of us who bear the image of God, the citizens of God’s kingdom, and godly institutions. Today he works to desecrate and destroy the image of God in male and female gender and in the institutions of marriage and the family. He ruins lives through selfishness, alienation, poverty, lack, drugs, gangs, injustice, sickness, and weakness. He works to diminish and destroy the value of human life in the world through every marginalization, slavery, and murder, including influence to murder those yet unborn. He seeks to destroy the reputation of God and His church. He still persecutes and murders God’s church throughout the world, causing much of it to operate underground.

The roaring lion looks for weak spots to attack. It prowls around, seeks especially those who are on their own. Further, our adversary looks to create and deepen both our vulnerabilities and our isolation.

The flip of destroy is create. The flip of murder is to give life. God created us to be able to create in a manner similar to the way He does (Romans 4:17). He created us to be channels of His life.

As children of the Creator, we are makers and doers (poiētēs, G4163, James 1:22). The word in the Greek for maker, author, doer, and poet is the same. As God’s workmanship (poiēma, G4161, Ephesians 2:10), we create through what we say, believing (Mark 11:22-24), and what we do. Since Christ lives in us to continue His ministry, we are meant to go about doing good in every way made possible, which brings glory to God. Every person we know and encounter is a good work that God has prepared for us in advance (Ephesians 2:10). Will we choose to do good to them? For those who are not disciples of Christ, will we seek with determination to add them to the family of God so they can pass from death to life?

As children of the Author of life, we are created to be channels of God’s abundant life (John 7:38-39). After making us alive through our identification with Jesus Christ (Ephesians 2:5), God seeks to fill us with His own life until it overflows out of us to others created in His image (Proverbs 11:25). We give life by way of our cooperation with the Spirit of God (1 Corinthians 3:9) to destroy the works of the devil (1 John 3:8): bondage, hunger, sickness, poverty, lack, injustice, hate, alienation, loneliness, fear, vengeance, selfishness, shame, and defeat. We give life by doing God’s word (James 1:22), Christ in us. We are to get up, get out there, and use what God gave us. That’s what faithful, responsible stewards of His life do.

Flipping strongholds

There is an ongoing battle for hearts and minds in this world. This world is claimed by God and counterclaimed by Satan.

What is the narrative you believe? Are you believing some lies? What strongholds have a hold on you?

Scripture warns us to give no place to the devil (Ephesians 4:27), but instead, to "..., walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh. For the desires of the flesh are against the Spirit, and the desires of the Spirit are against the flesh, for these are opposed to each other, to keep you from doing the things you want to do."

Galatians 5:16-17 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/gal.5.16-17.ESV>

Do you trust yourself too much? We need to be humble and watchful. We need to watch especially what we take in, for we become what we behold. We live into the narrative we take in.

As believers in Jesus living in this world, we must still choose if we will follow Christ's path of walking by the Spirit. The triumph of Jesus Christ was attained through His willingness to be led by the Spirit of God. The triumph of the Christian can be attained only in a similar manner. Even though God has baptized a soul with the Holy Spirit, there still remains for the person, as with Jesus, the present necessity of walking in humility and permitting the Spirit of God to be his or her absolute guide. The children of God are those led by His Spirit (Romans 8:14) to do the word of God (Luke 8:21), which is the will of God (Mark 3:35).

Is God's word living and active in you? We know the fruit of the Spirit (Galatians 5:22-25) relative to what is opposite of it. Living in this world, do not do those things that devils like to do, as this shows you have submitted to the wrong father (John 8:31-44). It is "for freedom Christ has set us free; stand firm therefore, and do not submit again to a yoke of slavery" (Galatians 5:1). We need to skillfully manage our attention.

When you permit the Spirit of God to be your absolute guide, the Spirit demolishes every stronghold of Satan, leading you in victory out of a lifestyle of sin. God has not only called you to be holy as He is holy (1 Peter 1:15-16), He has given You the Spirit that raised Jesus Christ from the dead (Romans 8:11) to accomplish that victory in you! Let Jesus Christ be your firm foundation (1 Cor 3:11) to stand on, and then stand firm, resisting the devil (James 4:7).

Only then may you join Christ in His work to destroy the works of the devil (1 John 3:8) in the lives of others. Only then may you follow Him in His triumphal procession (2 Corinthians 2:14), for Jesus Christ and His kingdom are coming into this world (John 11:27) to deliver us from evil (Matthew 6:13). The devil will have no strongholds left, for Christ will put all evil put under His feet (1 Corinthians 15:24-26). Dominion belongs to Christ, and in Christ we have dominion. He sets captives free. He makes things right. He makes people whole.

Will you cooperate with the leading of the Holy Spirit to be part of what Christ is doing?
Everything you take in, think on, say, and do matters.

May God make His church of single mind to carry out all of His perfect will (Matthew 6:22, 1 Corinthians 2:16, Romans 12:2).